

was sometimes employed on diplomatic missions. He composed secular music, including songs, but his work is mainly religious: there are 14 surviving Masses by him, among them the earliest known polyphonic Requiem Mass. His style is sophisticated, with intricate textures and harmonies, and a concentration on the unfolding of beautiful melody rather than dramatic word-setting.

KEY WORKS: Missa pro defunctis (Mass for the Dead); Missa cuiusvis toni (Mass in Any Mode); Ma bouche rit (My Lips Are Smiling); dates unknown

Josquin des Prez

c. 1450–1521, FRANCO-FLEMISH

Josquin was one of the most highly acclaimed musicians of his time, and in the generation after his death he became widely regarded as the supreme composer of the age. His fame was spread by the invention of printing: the first collection of printed music devoted to a single composer was a volume of his Masses published in Venice in 1502, and two other such collections followed in his lifetime. His early career was spent mainly in Italy, where he worked for two popes and the dukes of Ferrara